COUNTRY REPORTS: ERITREA

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Status report

GOVERNANCE · FINANCE · ICT INFRASTRUCTURE · DPI · DIGITALISATION · TECHNOLOGY · CAPACITY · INCLUSION · DATA · GEOPOLITICS

Governance

Strategies, plans and policies

Eritrea completed its first National Development Plan in 2025, and in April 2026 a domesticated UN Integrated Geospatial Information Framework action plan for Eritrea was filed with UNECA's African Centre for Statistics. A five-year civil registration and vital statistics plan for 2024 to 2028 also stands (July 2026).

Against that, the two policy areas most often taken as markers of a digital agenda are empty. No national broadband plan, strategy or policy has been adopted: the ITU and Broadband Commission's global inventory recorded none for Eritrea in 2019. Nor is there a published national AI strategy or a national digital transformation strategy (June 2026).

The planning framework with the most detail in it is jointly authored. The Sustainable Development Cooperation Framework for 2022 to 2026 was prepared under a joint government and UN steering committee, with the Ministry of Finance and National Development leading on the government side, and seeks to expand access to health coverage, education, social protection, energy and digital connectivity (2021).

Eritrea's Overall Governance score was 27.5 out of 100 in 2023 and 52nd of 54 African states, up 1.9 points over the decade with 1.5 of that gain in the last five years, when the African average gained 0.1.

Legislation and regulation

Eritrea's 2015 Penal Code, drafted to provide for computer crimes, had still not been enacted as at April 2026.

Two instruments are moving. The Public Procurement and Asset Management laws drafted under the African Development Bank's public financial management project remained in stakeholder consultation and unenacted in February 2026. A draft Law on National Archives and Libraries has been prepared with expert input from the Research and Documentation Centre and the University of Pavia (November 2025). Eritrea also acceded to the UN Convention on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities on 20 December 2024.

Nothing has been legislated for digital commerce. Neither the UNCITRAL Model Law on Electronic Commerce nor the Model Law on Electronic Signatures has been adopted, so electronic signatures carry no legal equivalence in Eritrean law (2022). The country is party to none of the three instruments governing refugee protection and has no national legal framework for refugees or asylum-seekers (2026).

For the financial sector, the Eastern and Southern Africa Anti-Money Laundering Group's July 2025 mutual evaluation found major technical compliance deficiencies in the anti-money-laundering regime and no operational financial intelligence unit.

Data protection

No comprehensive data-protection law was in force in Eritrea as at August 2026, no supervisory authority had been established and no enforcement decisions had been published. The only provision in point is Article 18 of the 1997 Constitution, a general right to privacy with no implementing statute: personal data is not defined in Eritrean law and no body holds a mandate to receive complaints or enforce data-protection obligations (2026).

The gap runs in both directions. No data-localisation requirement applies to the storage or processing of personal or government data (2026), while personal data is collected at the point of service with nothing around it: activating a prepaid mobile or fixed line with EriTel requires a copy of the subscriber's national identity card (2025). The Communication Department, the only body with power to supervise and regulate the communication sector, has little to no decision-making authority (2022).

Two external commitments point the other way. Article 15 of the Samoa Agreement commits Eritrea, as an OACPS party, to building a personal-data-protection regime overseen by an independent supervisory authority, and the Horn of Africa Initiative placed Eritrea with Djibouti, South Sudan and Sudan at a nascent stage without data-protection legislation or regulatory oversight, and put its regional target for national data-protection frameworks back from December 2025 to December 2026 (June 2025).

Complaint machinery is thin more widely: Eritrea has no independent children's ombudsperson or commissioner mandated to receive and investigate children's complaints, and the African Committee of Experts on the Rights and Welfare of the Child has recommended one be established in line with the Paris Principles (July 2026).

Regional collaboration

Eritrea is the only one of the African Union's 55 member states not to have signed the consolidated text of the African Continental Free Trade Area agreement, with 49 states having both signed and deposited instruments of ratification (July 2026).

It sits outside the region's digital work as well. Eritrea is not covered by the Eastern Africa Regional Digital Integration Project, IGAD's programme on connectivity, data governance, cybersecurity and cross-border data flows, whose coverage it gives as Djibouti, Ethiopia, Kenya, Somalia, South Sudan, Sudan and Uganda (January 2026). The World Bank found that cross-border links in the Horn would need cross-border collaboration on licensing (June 2021), and Eritrea has not signed the UN Convention on the Law of the Sea.

The exception is the Samoa Agreement, the EU-OACPS partnership agreement to which Eritrea is a party.

Two independent institutional accounts spanning 2021 to 2026 — a World Bank regional survey and IGAD's live regional digital programme roster — each place Eritrea outside the Horn of Africa's shared digital infrastructure and data-governance tracks.

Standards

The period's substantial standards adoption is operational rather than legal: Eritrea inaugurated the UNCTAD-built ASYCUDA World customs platform in January 2026, replacing a legacy customs system in place since 2007, with full source code transferred to the government.

Domestic standard-setting still rests on a single statute. Proclamation No. 75/1995 established the Eritrean Standards Institution as the sole autonomous national body for standardization, quality assurance and metrology, combining all three functions in one institution, empowered it to issue compulsory Eritrean Standards and to certify

imports and exports against them, and adopted the International System of Units as Eritrea's legal system of measurement. The Institution is a correspondent member of the International Organization for Standardization, observing on four technical committees (October 2026).

Inside government the connecting layer is absent: no interoperability framework and no data quality framework were recorded for Eritrea in 2022, and its wire-transfer regulations deviate from international security standards such as ISO/IEC and EMV (2022). Broadcasting has no independent regulator (January 2026), and Eritrea has made no submission to the ITU's telecommunications indicators questionnaire since 2017 (March 2026).

Public debate and participation in policymaking

The broadest consultation of the current period was foreign-funded and sectoral: Eurac Research's NBS4Water project brought more than 20 experts and stakeholders from government, academia, the private sector and NGOs through two rounds of geodesign workshops in July 2026 to co-develop water-security planning scenarios for Asmara.

Eritrea's deliberative and participatory governance score rose 7.4 points over the decade to 14.1 out of 100 in 2023, 52nd of 54 African states.

The channels around that are closed. Article 19 of the 1997 Constitution guarantees access to information, while the 1996 Press Proclamation requires all media to be licensed and publications to be approved before release, and no freedom-of-information law has been adopted (January 2026). Eritrea ranks last of 180 countries and territories in the 2026 World Press Freedom Index, the third consecutive year in that position, which names the Eritrean journalist Dawit Isaak as jailed without trial for 25 years (May 2026). The country's digital freedom score was 1.2 out of 100 in 2023, last of 54 African states and down 6.6 points over the decade, and freedom of expression and belief rose 12.6 points to 12.7 out of 100 over the same period, also last.

A UN Commission of Inquiry found in June 2015 that the state runs a complex, multi-layered system of surveillance of the population inside and outside the country, used to instil fear and keep it under control. Public consultation drafting does exist: The ABC Journey publishes some eighty consultation drafts of Acts, codes, regulations and rules, prepared against the 1997 Constitution for public debate rather than as enacted law.

Finance

Financial sustainability

No fiscal-year budget for the digital estate had been read as at September 2026.

MoUs and other agreements

Greenfield solar power plants at Tesseney, Berantu and Kerkebet were under discussion at the African Development Bank's mission to Eritrea in April 2026. The standing agreement covering United Nations cooperation, the Sustainable Development Cooperation Framework 2022-2026 signed with the Government of the State of Eritrea, was prepared under a joint government and UN steering committee.

New investments

The African Development Bank appraised Eritrea's Energy Integrated Project in February 2026 on two grants, UA 27 million from the African Development Fund and UA 15 million from the Transition Support Facility. The Bank's older engagement is smaller and nearly spent: UAC 9,000,000 approved on 4 July 2016 for the public financial management and statistics technical assistance project, in force from 10 October 2016, stood at 81.65 per cent disbursed at the Bank's supervision mission of 30 November to 30 December 2025. Its Fragile States Facility

approved UAC 2,000,000 on 19 June 2019 for the finance ministry's tax administration project. The United Nations Development Programme has financed national accounts and other macroeconomic statistics work with the National Statistics Office since 2019. The Global Partnership for Education's US$11.82m System Transformation Grant and US$2.2m System Capacity Grant, with UNICEF as grant agent, fund a foundational-learning programme that includes strengthening data collection, processing, storage and use in the education management information system, directed at the zobas holding nomadic, semi-nomadic and remote rural communities that lag the national average on education indicators (April 2024).

Eritrea's external development finance for digital and data systems is exceptionally thin (October 2026): five commitments in all, spanning 2016 to 2026, from three financiers — the African Development Bank with three, and the Global Partnership for Education and the United Nations Development Programme with one each. Every one of them is a grant or technical assistance to the public sector; there is no loan, no guarantee, no equity and no commercial or private-sector finance. The subsectors reached are energy, public financial management and tax administration systems, the education management information system and official statistics, and nothing at all has been committed for connectivity, digital identity, digital payments, data centres or digital skills. Eritrea is also named in none of the 29 regional East African digital commitments on the same record: the East African Community and IGAD-anchored programmes for regional digital integration, AI research, digital skills, cross-border payments and connectivity all run past it.

ICT Infrastructure

Connectivity

Eritrea was still the only one of Africa's coastal states with no submarine cable landing in April 2026. It has rebuffed approaches from submarine-cable firms seeking to use its waters, even at a price, as Houthi attacks left cables in Yemeni waters unrepaired and new ones unlaid, although its waters lie at a depth the industry regards as optimal (June 2024). The World Bank had already found that the regional submarine and festoon cable projects planned for the Horn of Africa, and the 2Africa cable, carry no commitment to serve the region as a whole, naming Asmara among the places left out (June 2021).

There is no active internet exchange point in the country (2026), and the ITU records no part of the population covered by a 4G network (2021); the newest international bandwidth figure the ITU holds, 8 kbit/s per internet user, is from 2017, the last year Eritrea filed telecommunications data at all.

The internet and computers score reached 23.5 out of 100 in 2023, 40th of 54 African states and up 22.4 points over a decade, while mobile communications, at 32.6, ranks 51st of 54 from a 2014 base of zero. Fewer than a quarter of the population used the internet in 2023.

Inside the country, limited internet infrastructure has led the Ministry of Health to run its health information platform offline over its own local networks, with data entered at zone and sub-zone level and analysed centrally (2024).

Data Storage

The state operator EriTel offers a private cloud service hosted entirely in its own data centres, in tiers of 100, 250 and 500 gigabytes for 20, 50 and 100 users, each with a 90 per cent uptime service level and a recovery-time objective of up to six days (August 2026), the only provider-hosted storage on the record. No capacity figure, facility count or location is published for it.

The one government data-centre build on the record sits inside the statistical office: African Development Bank financing approved in 2016 equipped the National Statistics Office with its own data centre.

The other place government data sits on infrastructure of its own is customs, where all stations are interconnected over a secure internal intranet so that data can be exchanged and processed without continuous internet access (January 2026) — a design built around unreliable national connectivity rather than evidence of it improving. Nothing joins them: Eritrea operates no government service bus, the shared middleware through which public bodies would route data to one another (2022), and it imposes no data localisation requirements on the storage or processing of personal or government data (2026).

Energy

Eritrea's interconnected grid has an installed capacity of 157 MW, of which only 52 MW is reliably available against demand of 74.3 MW (February 2026). Generation depends almost entirely on imported diesel, with renewable sources contributing 6 MW, and generation and distribution assets are ageing and breakdown-prone, with operations constrained by shortages of spare parts. Mining companies run 60 MW of captive generation of their own, outside the national grid.

Captive generation held by the mining companies is of the same order as the reliably available capacity of the entire national grid.

54.4% of the population had access to electricity in 2023, and access to energy is Eritrea's best-ranked infrastructure measure, 30.5 out of 100 and 32nd of 54 African states in 2023; supply is concentrated in the major cities and their surroundings (2018). 11.4% of electricity generation came from renewable sources in 2023, against the 2018 National Energy Policy target of 20% renewable supply by 2030, on a solar resource of 2,275-2,314 kWh/m2 a year at Tesseney, Kerkebet and Barentu.

The Energy Integrated Project appraised in February 2026 would build 34 MW of solar with battery storage serving Tesseney, Kerkebet and Barentu. It is the third African Development Bank energy intervention in the country, after a 30 MW plant at Dekemhare and a 12 MW mini-grid programme at the same three towns, and the Dekemhare solar plant is operational and supplying the national grid (April 2026).

The power estate now sits in front of the digital one: government-wide rollout of the financial management system is stated by its financier to depend on reliable power, IT infrastructure and connectivity upgrades (February 2026).

Technical Capacity

Eritrea's customs digitisation came with full transfer of the ASYCUDA World source code to the government and a ten-month capacity-building programme for 100 customs officers, IT specialists and private-sector clearing agents (January 2026), the largest single transfer of a working technical capability on the record. It sits against a UNDP assessment that scores implementation capacity and systems at their lowest stage: an analogue position with no skills, no outsourcing, no strategy and no budget (2024).

What capability exists has been built survey by survey and ministry by ministry. Computer-assisted personal interviewing replaced paper collection for the Fourth Round Population and Health Survey (May 2026), and a four-week UNECA workshop trained staff of the Ministry of Land, Water and Environment in GIS and remote sensing in Asmara (February 2026). The Ministry of Education rates its own teacher management system weak, and its technological infrastructure and connectivity inadequate (June 2025).

Technical and ICT capacity for civil registration is inadequate at both national and regional level (2022). The tertiary pipeline runs through the Eritrea Institute of Technology at Mai-Nefhi, which carries the country's computer science and related engineering programmes (2025). Eritrea sits near the bottom of the UN e-government ranking, 190th of 193 (2024).

Cybersecurity

Eritrea sits in the lowest tier, Building, of the ITU Global Cybersecurity Index 2024, the tier for scores of 0 to 20. No national cybersecurity strategy has been published (2024).

The 2015 Penal Code was drafted to provide for computer crimes but had not been enacted as at April 2026. Eritrea is also outside the Eastern Africa Regional Digital Integration Project, IGAD's programme on data governance, cybersecurity and cross-border data flows (January 2026).

The President has said that secure platforms and a data-protection architecture must be established before detailed personal data is collected for a planned diaspora database (January 2026).

DPI

Data Exchange

The one working data exchange went live in January 2026 and is confined to customs: all of the country's customs stations are interconnected over a secure internal intranet, so declarations move between them without depending on continuous internet access.

Nothing else in government exchanges anything. The UN Development Programme's Digital Development Compass placed Eritrea's data exchange at its lowest stage in 2024, describing government data handling as offline and paper-based with no systems in place. There is no government interoperability framework and no data quality framework and no government service bus, the middleware through which public bodies would route data to one another; as at 2022 none of the financial management, human-resource, customs, tax or social-insurance systems exchanged data with any other government system, and there was no GovTech or digital transformation strategy and no government body in charge of data governance. The Horn of Africa Initiative placed Eritrea's data-protection policy at a nascent stage in June 2025, with no legislation and no regulatory oversight.

Where data does cross an institutional boundary it travels as documents: an identity-card application requires a supporting letter from the applicant's kebabi administration and a birth certificate, lodged at one of 12 branch offices and forwarded to headquarters in Asmara for approval (2018).

The one recent move sits at the policy layer and is geospatial: a domesticated UN Integrated Geospatial Information Framework action plan for Eritrea was filed with UNECA's African Centre for Statistics on 6 April 2026.

Digital Identity and CRVS

A decade after the electronic card was introduced, most Eritreans still held the older hand-written identity card in November 2025, with a long backlog of applications behind the newer one. The plastic, holographic, fingerprinted card has been issued to citizens aged over 18 by the Department of Immigration and Nationality since late 2015; it carries a laser-engraved photograph, the holder's fingerprint and a unique serial number (2018).

Nor is there a single file behind it. Each of the six zoba registers records a per-resident identification number alongside biographic and civil-status fields, and residence and family cards are printed as extracts of that zoba's register rather than issued from a national one, fed by birth registration passed up from the Kebabi family register through Nus-Zoba to Zoba level. Issuance runs through the Department of Immigration and Nationality's 12 branch offices, with applications approved at its Asmara headquarters (2018).

The legal basis is thirty-four years old and silent on all of this: Proclamation No. 21/1992 remains the operative instrument for issuance and addresses neither digital identity, biometric data nor data protection, and no dedicated digital identity legislation has been enacted since. What does impose identity duties is anti-money-laundering law: Proclamation No. 175/2014 requires financial institutions to set customer identification and acceptance policies for business relationships and for cash transactions above US$10,000, with the Bank of Eritrea as supervisory authority.

The card is required of every Eritrean aged 18 and above; the UK passport authority confirmed in March 2026 that it remains a precondition of passport issue. It is also the gate to a telephone line: EriTel requires a copy of the identity card for a fixed line, and a regional administration letter, itself obtained with an identity card copy, for a prepaid mobile line (2025). It is not free — 100 nakfa for a new card in Eritrea and US$25 at the embassy in Washington (2018) — and limited access to documentation heightens the risk of statelessness (2026). Applicants in the United States can start an identity-card application on the embassy's online consular platform, in place since September 2024, and finish it in person.

Digital Payments and Fintech

A Bank of Eritrea legal notice of June 2026 ordered cash held outside the banking system deposited by 31 July 2026, on pain of legal action, into a system that had no automatic teller machines, no debit or credit cards and no internet banking when anti-money-laundering assessors visited in July and August 2024.

One licensed mobile wallet exists. M-Nakfa, run by a money transfer company under Bank of Eritrea licence, holds value backed by cash deposits and carries person-to-person transfers by phone number and merchant and utility payments, with registration at a branch on a national identity card or passport (2025). The state operator goes no further: EriTel transfers airtime credit between mobile numbers through a short code at 2 nakfa a transfer and takes fixed-line bill payments only in cash or cheque at its own pay stations as at 2025. Eritrea is not a participant in the Pan-African Payment and Settlement System, directly or through its extended network as at June 2026; money from abroad arrives through transfer operators, sending GBP 120 from the United Kingdom costing 8.42% on average in the third quarter of 2025. Its financial sector is small, simple and less integrated with the global financial system, owing largely to past UN sanctions and domestic restrictions on financial flows (July 2025). The Digital Development Compass scored payments at its lowest stage in 2024, cash and cheques dominating and digital payments rare, with none integrated into a government service.

None of this is prohibited. Electronic payments, credit cards and internet banking are not legally restricted. The financial system is instead owned and controlled by the State and offers what the evaluators call simple and less sophisticated services, and what the statute book does say constrains in other directions: Proclamations No. 32/1993 and No. 173/2013 require all transactions in Eritrea to be conducted in local currency, which UNECA reads as discriminating against foreign firms seeking to settle payments locally. Wire-transfer regulations deviate from international security standards such as ISO/IEC and EMV. The African Development Bank named an underdeveloped financial sector among the structural weaknesses limiting economic diversification in November 2025.

Registries

Eritrea's national vital statistics are still derived from Demographic and Health Surveys carried out in 1995, 2002 and 2010 rather than from routine registration, the country having no functional and complete civil registration and vital statistics system as at 2025. Civil registration is also the country's most deteriorated governance indicator of the past decade, down 37.5 points over 2014-2023 to 12.5 out of 100 and 53rd of 54 African states in 2023.

The population register is six registers. There is no central national file: six separate zoba-level digital population registers have run since 2001, each maintained independently of the others and used to print residence cards and family identity cards (January 2021). Beneath it, registration forms differ across regions, making records very difficult to collate into one national database, and civil status offices have yet to be established in some parts of the country, birth registration being rare in rural areas. A birth must be registered within 90 days at a civil registration office, late registration carrying a penalty, and a birth certificate issues on registration. A five-year Strategic Civil Registration and Vital Statistics Plan for 2024-2028 was recorded by the African Committee of Experts on the Rights and Welfare of the Child in July 2026.

The economic registers are statutory and manual. All land vests in the State, and the Cadastral Office under the Ministry of Land, Water and Environment is the sole national land register, created by Proclamation No. 95/1997; it had moved registration from manual to digital records except for the spatial part, while scanning old manual records into the database had stalled on delayed equipment procurement, and registration made mandatory in 1997 remained voluntary in practice (2023). The Business Information Register Proclamation No. 124/2002 obliges the Ministry of Trade and Industry to maintain a national business register and businesses to report to it annually by 15 January, on pain of licence suspension, while registering a business and obtaining a tax identification number are separate steps with no system integration (2020). No election has been held since 1993, although a draft Electoral Law, its proclamation number left blank, provides for an independent Electoral Commission, a voter register and voting cards. None of these registers connects to a national data exchange.

Sectoral management information systems

Eritrea's Integrated Financial Management Information System — seven modules covering budgeting, procurement, payroll, cash management, accounting, asset control and reporting — completed pilot rollout and user acceptance testing at the Ministries of Finance, Education and Agriculture, generating reconciled reports by the end of November 2025 and being declared ready for go-live. The same project has the country reporting public debt automatically each quarter and each year on the DMFAS platform since 2019.

At the revenue end, the Inland Revenue Department's integrated tax-administration system went to tender in September 2023, for deployment to every Inland Revenue office in the zobas with legacy data migrated from the current system. The Bank rated implementation satisfactory in June 2026, with licences, hardware and installation complete and the Release 1 requirements specification finished. Eritrea's tax and revenue mobilisation score nonetheless fell 22.2 points over 2014-2023 to 29.2 out of 100, 48th of 54 African states.

Health has the most developed system. The Ministry of Health has deployed DHIS2 across the national health system since 2015, installed locally and run offline over its own networks, with data entered at zone and sub-zone level and analysed centrally, and has introduced a tracker program for patient-level data (2024). The 2025 Joint External Evaluation scored early-warning surveillance at 3 out of 5 and pressed for a digitised, USSD-based national electronic disease-reporting system spanning health and agriculture.

In education, analysis of the Education Management Information System was used to diagnose the barriers behind the 2023-2027 Partnership Compact, and the ministry rated its own teacher information system weak in June 2025. A grant report of April 2026 records that the ministry developed new software to digitise the previously manual collection and management of education data, and completed the 2022-23 and 2023-24 statistical yearbooks.

Across sectors the systems stand apart: the social insurance and pension system run by the National Insurance Corporation of Eritrea neither exchanges data with other government systems nor uses the national identity number to identify beneficiaries.

Other GovTech and e-Gov

Eritrea scored 0.1576 on the UN's E-Government Development Index in 2024, 190th of 193 countries and in the survey's low group.

The exception is recent and sits in one agency. Eritrea inaugurated ASYCUDA World, the UNCTAD-built customs platform used in more than 100 countries, in January 2026, replacing a legacy customs system in place since 2007, and the implementation transferred full source code for the platform to the government.

Abroad, the embassy in the United States moved its consular work online in September 2024, on a platform built by the foreign ministry's own IT staff: applications for identity cards, visas and passport renewals start on an online form and are finished in person or by post.

Nothing comparable faces residents at home. There was no tax online service portal and no e-filing or e-payment service as at 2022, and digital payments are integrated with no government service at all. The commitment to change that is external: under Article 13 of the Samoa Agreement, which binds Eritrea, the parties undertake to accelerate the deployment of e-governance and digital public services and to digitalise public registries.

The administrative base underneath is where the movement, such as it is, has been. Eritrea's effective administration score rose 7.7 points over 2014-2023 to 32.7 out of 100, 46th of 54 African states, while public administration as a whole — civil registration, statistical capacity, administrative effectiveness, tax and budget management — fell 7.3 points to 26.8 out of 100 and 49th of 54, the sub-category holding the country's overall governance back the hardest.

Digitalisation

Digitalisation of sub-national government

What sub-national digital activity there is takes the form of training. The government's own account of a geographic information systems course held in Gash Barka in July 2026 puts it as addressing gaps in the region's existing information system and improving its documentation practices. An earlier course in Anseba, run by the regional administration with the national Research and Documentation Center, covered document organisation, preservation, evaluation and digital document management (September 2025).

Two such events are on the record between September 2025 and July 2026, in two of the country's six regions.

Rural digital data capture

Health data from the countryside is entered into the national DHIS2 platform at zone and sub-zone level, the platform running offline over the Ministry of Health's own networks because internet infrastructure is limited (2024).

Civil registration is thinnest in the same places. Civil status offices have yet to be established in some parts of the country, and birth registration is rare in rural areas, where many Eritreans hold no civil status documents (January 2021), while each zoba keeps its own digital population register.

The constraints behind that are physical: there is no commercial 4G network in the country at all (2021).

Remedies are aimed at the same places. Eritrea's education reform programme targets the zobas holding nomadic, semi-nomadic and remote rural communities, which lag the national average on most education indicators (April 2024), and a digitised national electronic disease-reporting system spanning health and agriculture was still a recommendation when the country was evaluated in August 2025.

Against all of that, rural economy is the single largest driver of Eritrea's decade of governance improvement, rising 18.1 points over 2014-2023 to 32.9 out of 100 in 2023, 42nd of 54 African states.

Technology

AI

The most visible use of AI touching Eritrea in 2026 was against it and about it: a wave of AI-generated images and video falsely showing Ethiopian forces occupying Assab and Eritrea's president fleeing circulated, made with consumer tools and widely shared by pro-Ethiopian accounts, while Eritrean-aligned users answered with AI video of Ethiopian troops surrendering (April 2026).

The state's own position on paper is empty. Eritrea has no dedicated AI law, no published national AI strategy and no AI regulator (June 2026).

Use is scattered and small. The health ministry took up CAD4TB, offline software that reads chest X-rays for tuberculosis, to screen people in remote areas, on the vendor's account of 2020. Language work runs outside the state: GeezLab's research programme releases Tigrinya and Tigre datasets and models openly, among them a 10.6K-pair question-answering benchmark and a named-entity corpus led by Mai Nefhi engineering students, with base language models in progress (2026).

ICT Industry

Outside the colleges, technical training for the sector includes Polytech, which, with three branches in Asmara and one in Massawa, teaches computer technology, electrical and electronic technology and audio-visual technology (July 2026). Industry supplies its own power on the same pattern, with mining companies running 60 MW of captive generation outside the national grid (February 2026).

Every external commitment on Eritrea's digital record is a grant or technical assistance to the public sector: there is no loan, no guarantee, no equity and no commercial or private-sector finance at all (September 2026).

Innovation ecosystem

Two small software projects surfaced in 2026, both reported by the information ministry's own outlet. Shambko Apps Group, a self-organised collective, has released five Tigrinya-language mobile applications built to the national curriculum (August 2026), and Afro Verse, a virtual-reality platform rendering traditional Hidmo housing in three dimensions, was shown in a first demo version on 27 August 2026.

A youth innovation hub has been running since 2023: the Youth Innovation and Entrepreneurship Hub, based with the National Union of Eritrean Youth and Students, gives programming, robotics and electronics training to secondary-school students and held a national science and innovation fair in March 2025 with all six regions taking part (2025). AI-generated displays appeared among the innovation exhibits at the National Festival in Asmara (July 2026).

Around that activity the commercial layer is thin, with the startup base still nascent (2026), and Eritrea sits outside the main international measure of it: it is not among the 133 economies ranked in the WIPO Global Innovation Index, the underlying data required for inclusion not being available (2024 edition). The statutory research mandate over information science and technology sits with ESTDA under its founding proclamation.

Capacity

Literacy

Eritrea scored zero out of 100 for education quality in 2023, 52nd of 54 African states, having fallen 16.7 points over the decade to 2023 — one of the ten most deteriorated of the 96 indicators the Ibrahim Index tracks for the country. Staffing is not what is failing: the same index places human resources in education among Eritrea's ten best scores, at 80.9 out of 100 in 2023, 29th in Africa and up 4.7 points over the same decade.

What sits between the two is enrolment. Education enrolment stood at 27.0 out of 100 in 2023, 44th of 54, and the education sub-category as a whole at 38.7, 43rd, down 4.1 points over 2014-2023 — one of the components pulling against the country's improvement on the index overall. Against that, a laptop programme for high-school students was launched in 2019, and the Ministry of Education launched an ICT in education initiative in January 2005, its 2018-2022 sector plan still finding ICT hard to bring into schools for lack of facilities, equipment and teacher training.

Training and skills

Mai-Nefhi College of Engineering and Technology conferred qualifications on 297 graduates on 18 July 2026, 289 first degrees and eight diplomas, a quarter of them women, the list including degrees in computer science and engineering and diplomas in computer application technology and in computer hardware and networking technology. The college is the successor to the Eritrea Institute of Technology, established at Mai-Nefhi in 2004 and restructured into autonomous colleges in 2018, which by its 2019 commencement was offering a computer engineering degree and diplomas in computer, communication and electrical and electronics technology, with a computer application diploma through its College of Science.

The larger recent additions to state skill are external, short and tied to single systems. A ten-month programme accompanying the customs digitisation trained 100 customs officers, IT specialists and private-sector clearing agents (January 2026). UNECA's African Centre for Statistics trained more than 25 Ministry of Land, Water and Environment staff over four weeks in Asmara in remote sensing, satellite land-use and land-cover classification and watershed analysis using ArcGIS Pro and QGIS, closing on 27 February 2026, as the second phase of a multi-year partnership with that ministry. Government employees across the Gash Barka regional administration and its sector branches completed a course in geographic information systems in July 2026.

What is trained is the equipment rather than the record. Instruction given to new recruits and serving police officers covers general computer maintenance and networking, and not any electronic records or case-management system (November 2025).

Outside the university there are two other channels. A three-month vocational programme for college students, run by the Sawa and higher-education branch of the National Union of Eritrean Youth and Students, carried computer technology among its trades (June 2026), and Polytech, a technical institute with sites in Asmara and Massawa, runs AI courses for beginners and content creators, about 50 students completing them in 2026. The state technical and vocational system itself grew from two schools with roughly 350 students in 1991/92 to six with 4,640 in 2010/11.

Research institutions

Eritrea's National Health Laboratory has built genomic-sequencing capacity since 2024 with WHO support, training 15 professionals — 13 from the Ministry of Health and two from the Ministry of Agriculture — and applying it nationally for the first time to malaria and antimicrobial-resistance surveillance, producing resistance-pattern data not previously available at national level (July 2026).

The other substantial build is in cultural heritage. The Research and Documentation Centre, supported through three successive EU-funded projects and working with Italy's University of Pavia, is equipped to digitise and preserve historic archives, manuscripts and audiovisual material (November 2025), and a draft Law on National Archives and Libraries has been prepared with expert input from the centre and the university.

The statutory architecture is older and sits elsewhere. Proclamation No. 122/2002 established a National Science and Technology Council chaired by the President, the Eritrean Science and Technology Development Agency and a National Science and Technology Advisory Board, gave the agency's research office an explicit mandate over information science and technology among its research domains, and empowered it to found research institutions, educational institutions and research foundations of its own. The most recent large research exercise on the record ran through the statistics office instead: the Eritrea Population and Health Survey 2025 was completed using digital data-collection tools.

Inclusion

Access to services

More than 679,000 Eritrean refugees and asylum-seekers were known to UNHCR worldwide by December 2025, hosted mainly by Ethiopia, Sudan, Germany, Uganda, Egypt and Switzerland. In April 2026 the agency issued a Guidance Note on Eritrea, replacing eligibility guidelines that had stood since 2011. Traffic the other way is negligible: Eritrea hosts 119 refugees under UNHCR's mandate (2026), and is party to none of the three refugee conventions and has no national law on refugee or asylum-seeker protection.

Equal access to public services scored 19.0 out of 100 in 2023, 47th of 54 African states and 0.8 points below its level ten years earlier. Entry is controlled at the door — obtaining a SIM card requires government approval, and the UNDP compass places civic engagement at its lowest stage, technology not being used for interaction between citizens and government (2024). The UN's 2024 e-government survey ranked Eritrea 190th of 193, reflecting very limited online service provision. The live public-facing channel that does exist is EriTel's internet complaint hub, a web form for reporting connectivity and web-access faults.

The gate to what services there are is paper. The identity card is required of every Eritrean aged 18 and above and is a precondition of passport issue (March 2026); the card remained in limited circulation in November 2025, most citizens still holding the older hand-written version. Civil status offices have yet to be established in some parts of the country (January 2021), and limited access to documentation raises the risk of statelessness (2026).

Eritrea acceded to the UN Convention on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities in December 2024. In July 2026 the African Committee of Experts on the Rights and Welfare of the Child found that the country has no independent children's ombudsperson able to receive and investigate complaints and recommended that one be established. There are no automatic teller machines, no debit or credit cards and no internet banking (August 2024).

Digital divides

Eritrea's most recent household survey of ICT use was taken in 2002, the oldest household-survey data year of any country in the ITU's Africa subregional dataset (March 2026). The Ibrahim Index put inclusion and equality at 23.4 out of 100 in 2023, 51st of 54 African states and 3.7 points below its level a decade earlier.

Where connectivity is measured, the movement is upward from nothing. The mobile communications score reached 32.6 out of 100 in 2023, 51st of 54 and the second most improved of that index's 96 indicators for Eritrea, the whole ten-year gain measured from a score of zero in 2014. Internet and computers stood at 23.5 out of 100, 40th of 54, up 22.4 points over the same period. The ceiling on that improvement is technological: there is no commercial 4G network in the country at all (2021).

Electricity, on which school ICT depends, is concentrated in the major cities and their surroundings, remote areas lacking any supply unless communities install diesel generators (2018).

The one funded attempt at closing a gap runs through schools: US$11.82m in Global Partnership for Education system transformation funding and US$2.2m in system capacity funding, with UNICEF as grant agent, targets the zobas holding nomadic, semi-nomadic and remote rural communities that lag the national average (April 2024). Women remained a minority of the graduates at Mai-Nefhi College of Engineering and Technology's July 2026 commencement.

Eritrea is named in none of the 29 regional East African digital commitments on its finance record — the East African Community and IGAD-anchored programmes for digital integration, AI research, digital skills, cross-border payments and connectivity all run past it (September 2026).

Data

National statistics

The National Statistics Office finished fieldwork on the fourth round of the Eritrea Population and Health Survey, covering 9,794 households across 405 enumeration areas at a 98.4% completion rate (May 2026), the first national survey of its kind in fifteen years and run on computer-assisted interviewing in place of paper, with UNFPA carrying half of its US$535,000 budget (2025).

It is a sample survey and not a census. Eritrea has held no population, agricultural or economic census in the past twenty years, and in September 2022 it was one of two African states not to have scheduled a census at the start of the 2020 round and, before this round, no household, labour force, health, agricultural or business survey in the past ten (2023). Its last household survey of ICT use dates from 2002, the oldest such data year in the ITU's Africa subregional set, and no return has been made to the ITU's telecommunications indicators questionnaire since 2017, the longest gap of any country in that set (March 2026). On the World Bank's 2023 reading the data infrastructure pillar scores below 20 per cent, data use between 20 and 49, and data products between 50 and 69, while data services and data sources are not scored at all.

A draft National Statistical Proclamation making the office the national statistical centre had been submitted to government but not enacted (January 2007), leaving it working without a dedicated statutory mandate. Its capacity score reached 35.9 out of 100 in 2023, 39th of 54 African states and up 18.3 points over the decade, among the country's fastest-improving governance measures, on an index holding no Eritrean data for eighteen of its 96 indicators. UNECA ran a two-week training in Eritrea in January 2026 on GDP compilation under the 2008 System of National Accounts and on its national accounts database system; African Development Bank financing has equipped the office with servers, computers and software for a data centre of its own (2025). Data on child labour, violence against children, child marriage and children in conflict with the law is not systematically collected, the African children's rights committee found in observations adopted in April 2026.

Open data

Eritrea scored 0.0 out of 100 for accessibility of public records in 2023, last of 54 African states and 6.3 points down over the decade, and 12.5 for disclosure of public records, 47th of 54 and unchanged across the same ten years. No freedom-of-information law has been adopted (January 2026).

Nothing is disclosed publicly about government data systems, data-sharing arrangements or interoperability work, and UNDP's Digital Development Compass places the open-government dimension at its lowest stage — closed, with no information sharing and no feedback or evaluation mechanisms (2022). Open datasets about the country are largely made elsewhere: WFP maintains subnational rainfall indicators for Eritrea on the Humanitarian Data Exchange, refreshed roughly every two weeks (July 2026).

Eritrea is party to the Samoa Agreement, whose general part commits its signatories to using digital solutions to widen public access to information; domestically, a draft Law on National Archives and Libraries has been prepared with expert input from the Research and Documentation Centre and the University of Pavia (November 2025).

Use of satellite data

The most recent dry-conditions alert covering Eritrea was issued not by the Eritrean state but by IGAD's regional climate centre, whose Climate Watch advisory of 10 August 2026, valid to 11 September, raised alert levels on May-to-July rainfall deficits using standardised precipitation analysis alongside soil-moisture and vegetation-stress monitoring. Eritrea has no modern national meteorological service: at the UNCCD's sixteenth conference of the parties its delegation listed setting one up among the country's forward strategies against drought and desertification (December 2024).

Routine satellite monitoring of Eritrean territory runs from outside it. WFP computes forecast, preliminary and final rainfall indicators for Eritrean subnational units from CHIRPS satellite precipitation imagery blended with station data and short-term forecasts, published on the Humanitarian Data Exchange and refreshed roughly every two weeks (July 2026). Eurac Research took high-resolution hydrological modelling and its geodesign platform to Asmara's Toker and Mainefhi catchments across two rounds of workshops in July 2026.

The state's own capability sits in the Ministry of Agriculture, whose Agricultural Strategic Information System Division, created in 2019, brings GIS and remote sensing, IT, an agricultural innovation unit and an expert system under one division and runs an agro-meteorological station network whose readings are passed to agricultural extension workers. Its desert locust information officers, who file monthly locust bulletins, were trained by FAO in September 2025 on the eLocust3 survey tool and satellite image analysis in Google Earth Engine. Geospatial skills are being built in a second ministry: UNECA's training of Ministry of Land, Water and Environment staff in remote sensing and satellite land-cover classification closed in Asmara in February 2026, and a domesticated UN Integrated Geospatial Information Framework action plan for Eritrea was filed with UNECA on 6 April 2026. The Cadastral Office's conversion of land registration from manual to digital had still not reached the spatial component in 2023.

Most of the satellite and geospatial work bearing on Eritrea is run from outside the country, by UN agencies, the regional climate centre and a European research institute; the agriculture ministry's information division is the state's own share of it.

Geopolitics

US / hyperscaler activities

United States sanctions imposed in November 2021 on the Eritrean Defense Force, the ruling PFDJ, the Hidri Trust and the Red Sea Trading Corporation were being moved toward removal in 2026, while other US restrictions and individual designations stood under separate legal authorities (August 2026).

China activities

No Chinese-funded or Chinese-built digital or data project was under way in Eritrea as at September 2026.

EU activities

European engagement with Eritrea's data capacity runs through institutions and heritage projects rather than through government digital programmes. The most recent of them is Eurac Research's NBS4Water project, which ran two rounds of geodesign workshops in Asmara in July 2026, applying high-resolution hydrological modelling to the city's Toker and Mainefhi catchments; its money comes from Italy's Autonomous Province of Bolzano, not from Brussels.

EU funding proper has gone to the Research and Documentation Centre in Asmara, supported through three successive EU-funded projects and, working with Italy's University of Pavia, equipped to digitise and preserve archives, manuscripts and audiovisual material as at November 2025. The same work has produced a draft Law on National Archives and Libraries, prepared with expert input from the Centre, the University of Pavia and an in-country team.

The treaty frame is the Samoa Agreement, published in the EU Official Journal in December 2023, which lists the State of Eritrea among the OACPS parties. What it asks of Eritrea it asks of every party: accelerating e-governance and the digitalisation of public registries, strengthening national statistical systems, building a personal-data-protection regime overseen by an independent supervisory authority, and using digital solutions to widen public access to information. All four sit in the agreement's General Part, which binds the whole membership alike.

Gulf/UAE activities

No Gulf or Emirati investment in Eritrea's data or digital infrastructure was under way as at September 2026.

India activities

No Indian government or industry involvement in Eritrea's data and digital sector was under way as at September 2026.

Digital sovereignty

Eritrea owns the code of its newest national system: the ASYCUDA World customs platform inaugurated in January 2026 came with complete transfer of its source code to the government, and national IT staff had already begun customising it. Its central servers sit in a solar-powered server room serving every customs station over an internal network, and a ten-month programme trained 100 customs officers, IT specialists and clearing agents to operate it.

Beyond customs nothing fixes where state data sits: no data-localisation requirement applies to the storage or processing of personal or government data (2026), and there was no shared cloud platform for government entities and no government cloud hosting policy (2022). The domestic hosting on the record is small: EriTel's Nextcloud private-cloud service is hosted entirely in its own data centres (August 2026), and African Development Bank financing equipped the National Statistics Office with a data centre of its own. Where the six zoba population registers and the identity-card database are hosted, and under whose jurisdiction, had not been published as at September 2026.

The AI layer has no policy over it: Eritrea has no published AI strategy, no AI law and no AI regulator (June 2026). Nor is it in the regional layer, sitting outside IGAD's Eastern Africa Regional Digital Integration Project, the region's programme on data governance and cross-border data flows (January 2026).

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